

This solid move is the strongest. After 25 Bxg5 Qf2+ 26 Kh1 Qxb6 White has lost control of the position.

25...Bxe3 26 Qxe3 Rb8 27 Rf1 Qe7 28 Qh6 (Diagram 18)

Suddenly the black king is in a precarious position. His next move cost him his d-pawn but other moves were no better. For example, 28...Ng5 29 Nxc8 Rxc8 30 Qh5 and White wins the g-pawn.

28...Bd7 29 Nc4 b5 30 Nxd6 Rb6 31 Nf5! Rxh6 32 Nxe7+ Kh8 33 Rf8+ Kg7 34 Rd8 Black resigns

I would have played one more move as after 34...Rf6 if White carelessly plays 35 Rxd7?? then 35...Rf2+ 36 Kh1 Rf1+ 37 Kg2 Rg1 is mate. Instead White should just play 35 Nd1! when the only way to save the bishop, 35...Rd6, loses to 36 Nc8!.

NOTE: The stronger players become, the earlier they resign as they understand how hopeless the situation is. Still, there is nothing to be gained by resigning too early. The above was definitely one move too soon.



Game 6

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1 d4 Nf6 2 Nf3 g6 3 c4 Bg7 4 Nc3 0-0 5 e4 d6 6 Be2 e5 7 Be3 Ng4 8 Bg5 f6 9 Bc1

This retreat is not played so often here but it is still an important variation as it can be reached via another move order (see below).

9...Nc6 10 0-0

Blocking the centre with 10 d5 is a reasonable alternative. The position after 10 0-0 is more commonly reached via the move order 7 0-0 Nc6 8 Be3 Ng4 9 Bg5 f6 10 Bc1. The reason White usually plays 10 Bc1 there, as opposed to 10 Bh4, is that having already castled king-side he doesn't want to encourage Black to advance his pawns there.

10...f5

Black has a wide choice. 10...Nh6 and 10...Kh8 lead to complex games while the variation 10...exd4 11 Nxd4 Nxd4 12 Qxd4 f5 13 Qd5+ Kh8 14 Bxg4 fxg4 15 Be3 c6 16 Qd3 Be6 17 Rad1 Bc5 18 Bd4 leads to a much quieter game.

11 Bg5

11 d5 Ne7 12 Ng5 Nf6 occurs occasionally. This is similar to Games 23 and 24.

11...Qe8!

11...Bf6 12 Bxf6 Nxf6 13 exf5 Bxf5 14 d5 Ne7 15 Ng5 is supposed to be a little better for White.

12 dxe5

After 12 d5 Black has tried many knight moves. 12...Ne7 or 12...Nd8, intending ...Nf7, are the best choices.

12...dxe5 13 h3

13 Nd5 is probably a better move although after 13...Qf7 the position is thought to be about equal.

13...Nf6 14 Bd3 Be6 15 Re1 Qf7 16 c5? (Diagram 19)

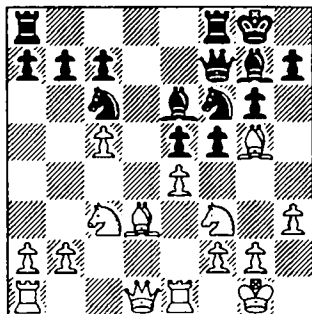


Diagram 19

White's c-pawn becomes a target

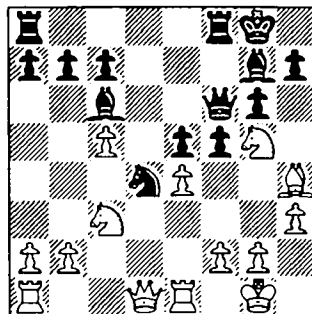


Diagram 20

The black queen pins and wins

Some of White's last moves may have been questionable but this is the real mistake as the c-pawn just gets into trouble. After something like 16 Bxf6 Bxf6 17 Nd5 White shouldn't be worse.

16...Nd7! 17 Bb5 Nd4 18 Bxd7 Bxd7 19 Bh4?! Bc6 20 Ng5 Qf6! (Diagram 20)

Black threatens to win a piece with ...h7-h6 and there is no good discovered attack with the knight. Of course 21 Nf3 is just met by 21...Nxf3+ and 22...Qxh4.

21 exf5 gxf5 22 Ne2

After 22 Qh5 h6 23 Nge4 Qf7! the queens will be exchanged leaving White facing the double threat of ...fxe4 and ...Ne2.

22...Rad8 23 Nxd4 Rxd4 24 Qh5 h6! White resigns

After 25 Nf3 Bxf3! Black wins a piece

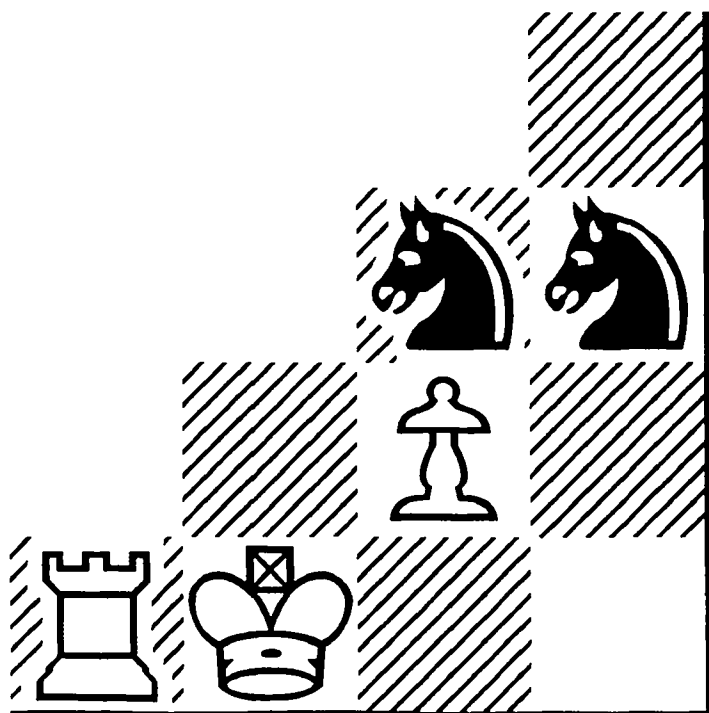
Summary

- 1) The Exchange Variation deserves all the stick I have given it. I have nothing against exchanging queens and trying to win an end-game, but only when it is positionally justified. Here it certainly isn't.
- 2) The Petrosian System is a much more serious alternative to 7 0-0 and a genuine way for White to play for an advantage. However, most players believe it is a little premature for White to block the centre.
- 3) The Gligoric System is a dangerous line which has plenty of high level support. The line with 9 Bh4 is more dangerous than 9 Bc1.

Chapter Two

The Classical with 7 0-0: Alternatives to 7...Nc6

- ▨ The Modern 7...Na6
- ▨ The Old 7...Nbd7
- ▨ Black Exchanges with 7...exd4



The Modern 7...Na6

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Nf3 0-0 6 Be2 e5 7 0-0 Na6
(Diagram 1)

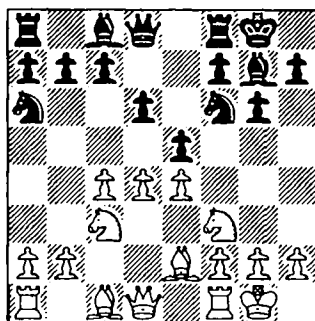


Diagram 1
The modern approach

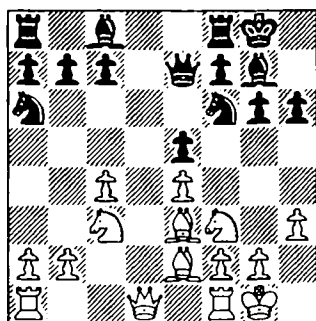


Diagram 2
Inviting Nd5

This is by far the most topical line in this chapter. It is a totally new system that has developed in the 1990's. It has become an important refuge for those who want to play the King's Indian but don't want to get involved in the heavy theoretical battles that often arise from 7...Nc6.

Isn't the knight badly placed on the edge?

On a superficial reading of the position the knight is indeed badly placed on the edge of the board. The move would appear to go against the basic chess principles of controlling the centre. However, once we look a little more closely we can see that this is not the case. White will not be able to hold the tension in the centre forever and at some point he is either going to take on e5 or play d5. In both cases the knight on a6 is poised to jump into c5, one of its best squares in the King's Indian. On other occasions Black, himself, may relieve the central tension by playing ...e5xd4 and here, too, the square c5 becomes available to the knight. If for some reason Black is unable to play ...Nc5 then there is an alternative method of bringing it back into play: ...c7-c6, followed by ...Nc7 and ...Ne6.

The move ...Na6 is more flexible than the old 7...Nbd7 line that we study below as it doesn't interfere with the development of the rest of Black's queenside.

8 Be3

This is the most common move and the position is important for the King's Indian as it can also arise via the move order 7 Be3 Na6 8 0-0.

The other main line is 8 Re1 and that is covered in Game 8. The other alternatives are:

- 1) 8 dxe5 dxe5 9 Qxd8 Rxd8, as usual, offers White nothing.
- 2) 8 d5 Nc5 9 Qc2 a5 was considered briefly in Game 3.
- 3) 8 Bg5 has become quite popular. The variation 8...h6 9 Bh4 Qe8 10 Bxf6 Bxf6 11 c5!, which has occurred quite often, is not totally reliable for Black. It is simpler to play the more direct 9...g5 10 Bg3 (10 dxe5 Nh5 11 Bg3 Nxd5 12 hxd5 dxe5 just transposes) 10...Nh5 when 11 d5 Nf4 transposes to a line in the Petrosian system which is not considered dangerous for Black and 11 dxe5 Nxd5 12 hxd5 dxe5 is level.

8...Ng4

Just as in the 7 Be3 variation the bishop is not allowed to settle on this square.

9 Bg5 Qe8!

In the early days of the variation Black often played 9...f6 but went off this line because of the continuation 10 Bc1 c6 11 h3 Nh6 12 c5!.

10 dxe5

This exchange is considered to be the most accurate move. After 10 h3 h6! 11 Bc1 exd4 12 Nxd4 Nf6 13 Bf3 Black has demonstrated on a number of occasions that the move 13...Nh7!, intending ...Ng5, gives him a comfortable game.

10...dxe5 11 h3

11 Nd2 is an important alternative. Black can try:

- 1) 11...h6 12 Bh4 Nf6 13 Nd5 Qd8?! (13...g5 14 Bg3 c6 15 Ne3 Nc5 is more solid with good equalising chances for Black; he does have a hole on his f5-square but he will always be able to take a white knight that occupies this square) 14 f4! and now Black must sacrifice his queen. After 14...Nxd5! 15 Bxd8 16 Qb3 Nxf1 17 Nxf1 Rxd8 he probably does not have quite enough compensation.
- 2) Recently Black has started playing 11...f6!? and has been doing fine after both 12 Bh4 h5 and 12 Bxg4 fxg5.

11...h6

11...f6 is also playable here.

12 Bd2

White can win a pawn with 12 hxd4 hxd4 13 Nxd4 Qe7 14 Nh3 but Black has excellent compensation on the dark squares after 14...Bh6. His main plan now will be to manoeuvre the knight from a6 to d4.

12...Nf6 13 Be3 Qe7!? (Diagram 2)

This crazy-looking queen move, which seems to invite Nd5, is designed to prevent White from playing c5. It has become the main line and is featured in Game 7.